Australia Day: A Celebration or a Day of Mourning?



Celebration



Protest



LOOK · THINK · TALK

One date, two very different experiences

Look at the two images. One shows celebration; the other shows protest. Why might people feel differently about January 26?

Discuss with a partner: What can a national day mean to different groups?

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · VOCABULARY

Vocabulary: match the words and definitions

Match 1–5 with A–E. Then predict: What might the two perspectives say?

Word	Definition
invasion	entering a country with an army to take control
mourning	deep sadness after a death or tragic event
controversial	causing disagreement or argument
treaty	a formal agreement between groups
resolution	a formal statement or decision voted on by a group

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Why is January 26 controversial?

1788

The First Fleet arrived at Sydney Cove and Captain Arthur Phillip raised the British flag.

For many Australians

This marks the beginning of modern Australia.

For many First Nations people

The date marks invasion, the loss of land and culture, and a painful historical turning point.



PERSPECTIVE 1

“It’s a day to celebrate”

Celebrate

Mark, Sydney: Australia Day is a time for barbecue, beach and family.

Mark’s view

It celebrates a peaceful, multicultural and successful nation.

He believes the country should keep January 26, respect First Nations people, and focus on the future rather than trying to change history.

PERSPECTIVE 2

“It’s a day of mourning”

Mourn

Tanya, an Aboriginal activist: January 26 is the anniversary of invasion.

Tanya’s view

Between 1788 and 1900, the Indigenous population was reduced by as much as 90% because of disease and violent treatment.

In 1938, Aboriginal leaders protested the mistreatment of Aboriginal people. Today, many people want a date that includes everyone.

Read, compare, and find the difference

Complete the table while you read.

Question	Celebrate	Mourn
What is January 26?	A day to celebrate the country and the beginning of modern Australia	The anniversary of invasion and loss of land
Key facts	First Fleet arrived in 1788; the British flag was raised	Up to 90% population loss; protest in 1938
What is the solution?	Keep the date and celebrate together	Change the date so it includes everyone

INDEPENDENT CHECK

Check your understanding

Answer with complete sentences and one fact from the texts.

1. What happened in 1788?

2. Why is January 26 painful for many Indigenous Australians?

3. What happened in 1938?

4. What percentage of the Indigenous population was lost between 1788 and 1900?

5. What solution does each perspective suggest?

FORMAL DEBATE

Change the date or keep the date?

Motion: “Australia Day should be moved to a different date.”

Team A

Argue for the motion.

Use the perspective that wants a date that includes everyone.

Team B

Argue against the motion.

Use the perspective that wants to keep January 26.

1. Prepare your team — 3 minutes.
2. Opening statements — 2 minutes.
3. Open discussion — 5 minutes.
4. Closing statements — 2 minutes.

Use the facts: 1788, 1938 and up to 90% population loss.



Useful language for a respectful debate

- “We strongly believe that…”
- “According to the text, in 1788…”
- “I understand your point, but I disagree because…”
- “To sum up, our position is the most reasonable because…”

Challenge ideas, not people.